SkillNavora

MODULE 4 HANDBOOK

Module 4: Contact Management and Data Architecture

4 sections, 33 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 4: Contact Management and Data Architecture

Level: Beginner. Contacts, subscribers and keys, and how the data is modelled so that every message reaches the right person.

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Detailed lessons

Module 4

4.1 Subscribers, contacts and keys

WHAT IS IT?

> A subscriber is a person in Email Studio, identified by a subscriber key. A contact is a person in Contact Builder, identified by a contact key, and one contact can own several subscribers (for example, one per email address or business unit). Subscriber keys must be unique and stable.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Wrong keys are the most common cause of duplicate emails and lost unsubscribes.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose a stable identifier (customer ID) as the subscriber key.
2. Never use the email address as the key if the address can change.
3. Check that the contact key matches the subscriber key in your model.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customer 10045 changes email address; the subscriber key stays 10045, so history and unsubscribes still apply.

COMMON ERRORS

Using email address as the key, then creating a new subscriber each time the address changes.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between a subscriber key and a contact key?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List three possible subscriber key choices for a retailer and pick one with a reason.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

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4.2 Data architecture: keys, relationships and data views

WHAT IS IT?

> Relational data uses primary keys (unique identifiers) and foreign keys (links to other tables). In SFMC, data extensions are the tables; relationships are modelled with keys and in Contact Builder.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A clear model avoids joins that multiply rows and produce wrong counts.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the primary key for each data extension.
2. Define the foreign key that links orders to customers.
3. Draw the relationship diagram before building.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers (CustomerID primary) and Orders (OrderID primary, CustomerID foreign).

COMMON ERRORS

Joining on a non-unique field, which multiplies rows.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a primary key and why must it be unique?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the data model for customers, orders and products and label the keys.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

4.1 Contact Fundamentals: every topic explained

Contacts. People known to Marketing Cloud across channels, managed in Contact Builder.

Subscribers. People in Email Studio who can receive email, with a status per list.

Leads. Prospects not yet customers, often synchronised from Sales Cloud.

Customers. People who have bought or subscribed.

Subscriber keys. The unique identifier of a subscriber in Email Studio. Use a stable customer ID.

Contact keys. The unique identifier of a contact in Contact Builder. Usually the same value as the subscriber key.

Contact IDs. A system-generated internal ID for a contact.

Email addresses. Delivery addresses; they can change, so they should not be the key.

Contact lifecycle. How contacts are created, updated, kept and deleted over time.

4.2 Contact Model: every topic explained

Contact model versus subscriber model. The subscriber model is email-centric; the contact model is cross-channel and keyed by contact key.

Contact Builder. The tool to view contacts, relationships, data extensions and imports.

All Contacts. The list of all contacts across channels in the account.

All Subscribers. The master list of email subscribers and their status.

Contact deletion. Removing contacts and their channel data when required, using the contact deletion process.

Contact status. Whether the contact is active or marked for deletion.

Subscription status. Per-list and global subscription status (active, unsubscribed, held, bounced).

Contact relationships. Links between a contact and their data in other data extensions.

4.3 SFMC Data Architecture: every topic explained

Data architecture fundamentals. How data is organised, stored, linked and governed.

Relational data concepts. Data in tables with rows and columns, linked by keys.

Data relationships. One-to-one, one-to-many and many-to-many links between tables.

Primary keys. A field (or fields) that uniquely identifies each row.

Foreign keys. A field that points to a primary key in another table.

Data normalisation. Splitting data into related tables to remove duplication.

Data extensions. The custom tables in SFMC.

Data views. System tables of tracking data, queried with SQL.

Shared data extensions. Data extensions in the shared folder used by several business units.

4.4 Data Modelling: every topic explained

Customer data model. Core customer table: key, name, contact details, consent, attributes.

Transaction data model. Orders and order lines linked to customers.

Product data model. Products with ID, name, category and price for recommendations.

Campaign data model. Campaigns and sends with IDs to link tracking to business results.

Consent data model. Consent records: channel, purpose, date and source.

Event data model. Events such as page views, cart events and app actions with timestamps.

Contact relationship modelling. Diagram of how all these tables relate to the contact.